FREE ASSESSMENT GUIDE

Do I Need an Assessment?

A guide to psychological and developmental assessments for children and adults

What they involve, who they help, how to prepare and what to expect afterwards.

eMbrace Lives

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START HERE

What is an assessment, really?

Many families arrive at an assessment with the same quiet questions: "Is something wrong?", "Will this label them?", "What will it involve?". This guide answers them plainly, for children, teens and adults.

An assessment is a way of understanding, not a verdict

A good psychological or developmental assessment brings together your history, careful observation and standardised tools to explain *how a person thinks, learns, feels and behaves*, and what support would help most.

A good assessment answers three questions

What is going on?

Clear, evidence-based explanation of strengths and difficulties, with a diagnosis only where the criteria are met.

Why is it happening?

Looks at development, learning, emotions, sleep, health and environment, not one factor in isolation.

What helps now?

A practical plan: therapy, home strategies, school support and referrals where needed.

Who can benefit

- **Toddlers and preschoolers** with delays in speech, play, social interaction or movement.
- **School-age children** who struggle with attention, learning, behaviour, friendships or anxiety.
- **Teens** facing falling grades, mood changes, exam stress or school refusal.
- **Adults** who suspect ADHD, autism, anxiety or long-standing patterns that have never been explained.

TYPES OF ASSESSMENT

Which assessment is which?

Different questions call for different tools. Often a clinician combines several. Here are the ones families ask about most.

Assessment	What it looks at	Typical tools
Developmental	Early milestones in movement, speech, play, social skills and self-care, usually for toddlers and preschoolers.	Developmental history, structured observation, standardised developmental scales
Autism	Social communication, interaction, play and repetitive or sensory patterns, at any age.	ADOS-2, developmental interview, observation
ADHD	Attention, activity and impulse control across home, school and work.	Conners-3 and other rating scales, interview, observation
Cognitive	Reasoning, memory, processing speed and verbal and visual skills: a child's learning profile.	WISC-V and age-appropriate cognitive measures
Psychoeducational / learning	Reading, writing and maths skills compared with ability, to identify specific learning difficulties.	Cognitive plus achievement testing, school work review
Emotional and behavioural	Anxiety, mood, anger, social difficulties and coping, in children and teens.	BASC-3 and other questionnaires, clinical interview
Speech, language and OT	Speech sounds, language use, sensory processing, fine and gross motor skills.	Speech-language and occupational therapy assessments

You do not need to know which one you need. A first consultation helps decide the right combination, so you are not over- or under-tested.

IS IT TIME?

Signs it may be time to seek an assessment

Tick what you recognise. Several ticks, lasting more than a few months, are a good reason to talk to a professional.

For children and teens

- [ ] Speech or language seems behind other children of the same age
- [ ] Struggles to pay attention, sit still or control impulses
- [ ] Reading, writing or maths is much harder than their effort or ability suggests
- [ ] Strong reactions to sounds, textures or changes in routine
- [ ] Difficulty making or keeping friends, or very rigid play
- [ ] Frequent worry, meltdowns, anger or low mood
- [ ] A teacher or doctor has suggested a closer look
- [ ] School refusal or a sudden drop in grades

For adults

- [ ] A lifelong pattern of disorganisation, lateness or unfinished tasks
- [ ] Constant mental restlessness or difficulty focusing at work
- [ ] Social situations are exhausting, or you often feel you do not fit
- [ ] Anxiety, low mood or burnout that keeps returning
- [ ] Recognising yourself in your child's assessment
- [ ] Needing clarity for workplace support or accommodations

THE PROCESS

What happens, step by step

At eMbrace the process is collaborative and unhurried. The number of sessions depends on what needs to be explored.

1. **Initial consultation**
   You share your concerns and goals. The clinician explains the process and recommends the right assessment. No pressure.
2. **History and background**
   Developmental, medical, family and school or work history, collected through discussion and short forms.
3. **Questionnaires from home and school**
   Standardised rating scales completed by you and, for children, teachers, give a picture across settings.
4. **One-to-one assessment**
   Direct, age-appropriate tasks and observation with a qualified clinician. Breaks are built in.
5. **Scoring and integration**
   Results are interpreted together with history and observations, and other conditions are considered.
6. **Feedback session and report**
   A clear explanation of the findings, a written report, and a personalised plan.

Preparing your child

Keep it light and honest: “We’re going to meet someone who plays games and asks questions to understand how you learn best.” Make sure they have eaten and slept well, and bring glasses or hearing aids if used.

GET READY

How to prepare

Bring or have ready
☐ Recent school reports and teacher comments, or work samples
☐ Any previous assessments, medical records or therapy reports
☐ Your list of concerns and examples (the log on the last pages helps)
☐ A short video of behaviours that are hard to describe, if relevant
☐ Details of milestones: first words, walking, sleep and feeding patterns
☐ Questions you want answered

Questions to ask any clinic

- Who will assess my child, and what are their qualifications and registration (for example RCI-registered clinical psychologists)?
- Which tools will be used, and why those?
- How long will the process take, and how many sessions?
- Will I receive a written report and a feedback session?
- Can the report be used for school accommodations?
- What support is available after the assessment?

Green flags and red flags

Green flags: detailed history taking, more than one source of information, internationally recognised tools, a clear feedback session and report. **Red flags:** a diagnosis after a short chat or a single questionnaire, no written report, pressure to start expensive therapy immediately.

AFTER THE ASSESSMENT

What you receive and what happens next

The report

Background and reasons for assessment

Results explained in plain language

Strengths as well as difficulties

Diagnosis where criteria are met

Practical recommendations

The feedback session

Time to ask questions

Guidance on what the results mean in daily life

How to share findings with your child and the school

Choosing priorities, so you are not overwhelmed

The plan

Therapy such as behavioural, speech or occupational therapy

Parent coaching and home strategies

School accommodations and a support plan

Referral to a psychiatrist or paediatrician if medication is being considered

Using the report at school or work

- Share the report with the class teacher or school counsellor and ask for a meeting to agree on accommodations.
- For learning difficulties, many schools and boards allow accommodations such as extra time or a reader or scribe. Rules vary by board, so check the current guidelines.
- Adults can use a report to request reasonable adjustments, such as flexible deadlines or a quieter workspace.

Myths about assessments

The myth	The reality
"An assessment will label my child."	It explains what is going on so the right support can begin. Not knowing is often harder.
"It is one test."	It is a process using several sources of information, not a single score.
"They are too young."	Developmental concerns can be assessed in toddlers, and early support makes a difference.
"It's only for children."	Adults can be assessed too, and many receive their first explanation in adulthood.

PRINT AND FILL IN

Your assessment preparation worksheet

Jot down what you have noticed. Specific examples are the most useful thing you can bring.

What worries me most right now

Situation (home, school, work)	What happens	How often	How long has it been going on

Strengths and things that go well

My questions for the clinician

NEXT STEP

Take the next step with eMbrace

Ready for clarity? Let's talk.

If this guide has made you feel an assessment could help, a first consultation is the best next step. Our RCI-certified clinical psychologists, speech and occupational therapists work together under one roof, in person or online.

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